

Headline Writing

Invitational B Meet • 2026



You are a copy editor for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

Write the headline assigned for each of the given **six** stories. Use the following system: all upper and lower case letters, spaces, punctuation marks and symbols count as 1. Capitalize the first letter of the first word of each headline. You may use either upstyle (capitalizing the first letter of every word) or downstyle (capitalizing the first letter of the first word and the first letter of proper nouns only thereafter). Remember that main headlines belong on the top line and secondary headlines belong under the main headline. You have **30 minutes**. Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Story 1 — Write: 1-line headline counting 26-32

As part of their search for a new cafeteria contractor, the school will host a taste-testing event Friday right after school where three food contractors will provide small bites for students to sample and vote on their favorites.

“We got this idea from a district in another state,” nutrition services director Keith Jernigan said. “It won’t be our only factor in choosing a food contractor, but it will play into the decision and give us some feedback to give to these companies.”

Representatives from three companies will each provide small bites of a main entree, a dessert and cheese pizza.

“I think it’s awesome that they’re giving students the opportunity to give feedback here,” junior Julia Margueliz said. “I’ve always thought our cafeteria food was pretty disgusting here, so I’m looking forward to at least have something different.”

Story 2 — Write: 2-line headline with each line counting 22-28

Benjamin Franklin Autoparts stores have agreed to donate more than 80,000 individual parts to provide hands-on experience in the new automotive technology class, which started in August.

Students spent the first semester practicing car maintenance procedures on a classroom vehicle, but with the donation of parts and materials, they will begin service and maintenance on vehicles in the community.

“First semester was a great experience,” sophomore Landry Davis said. “But now that we have a stockpile of basic parts and materials, we’ll actually be able to have people bring their cars to us when they need service.”

Teachers are eligible for discounted oil changes and routine maintenance with the new program. Benjamin Franklin Autoparts manager Steve Stills said he plans to work with students for two hours every week to provide mentorship.

“I loved working in my dad’s garage,” Stills said. “He was an auto mechanic his whole career, and his salary was great for our family. It’s wonderful to see programs like this that can teach students how to earn a living right out of high school.”

Story 3 — Write: 3-line headline with each line counting 16-22

Crews will begin to apply transparent film to the main hall windows starting Feb. 17 to prevent birds from crashing into the building.

Currently, birds see the floor to ceiling windows as solid reflections of the ground and sky but do not see the window glass itself. This can cause them to fly into the windows, often at speeds high enough to cause injury or death.

“I hate seeing that little outline of a bird on our hallway windows,” Principal Lane Price said. “I’ve been trying to get someone to invest in a protective window covering for years, and we finally found the funds.”

The film covering will still be transparent but will have small periodic markings that will prevent the windows from being totally reflective.

“I’m looking forward to the day when we don’t walk down the main hall and see dead or confused birds in the grass outside the building,” junior Tracy Marion said. “It’s disturbing, and it’s the school’s responsibility to make sure it stops. I’m glad they’re finally doing something to stop it.”

Story 4 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 8-14 and 2-line secondary headline with each line counting 20-26

District Attorney Betty Whitman will visit senior English classes next Monday to discuss the power of language and persuasion in her career. The invitation came after English teacher Janice Norrell served on a jury panel in January and was impressed with Whitman's presentation skills.

"All of her statements to the jury and her questions to witnesses were so precise and well thought out," Norrell said. "I immediately thought we needed to get her in front of students so they can see where some of these skills could take them in their careers."

Whitman said she plans to discuss her personal "rules of trial" that she has established for herself to keep her cases on track.

"A lot goes into putting a case together," she said. "We have a whole team of professionals in the DA's office that helps us gather evidence and decide how to present that evidence effectively. Writing and speaking is a huge part of that. We even put time into selecting the right fonts when we need to show slides to the jury."

Senior Kelsey Lane said she has always been interested in being a prosecutor.

"I'm looking forward to meeting the speaker," she said. "Law school is a huge goal of mine, and ever since I saw the movie 'The Firm,' I've wanted to be a lawyer."

Story 5 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 10-16 and a 1-line secondary headline counting 26-32

Students in culinary classes will use their original recipes to compete at the 12th annual Leaguetown Pickle Fair Saturday. Students began developing their concoctions during fall semester, and 11 groups will present their final results to see who came up with the tastiest pickle dish.

Seniors Venelope Madigan and Rudy Vasquez will present a garlic and dill marinated pork tenderloin with pickled radishes and roasted potatoes.

"I don't even like pickles," Madigan said. "But after tasting this dish umpteen million times, they're starting to grow on me. Our food is complex and playful. I think we have a good chance."

Judges, who are chefs from local restaurants, will score the dishes on taste, originality and "pickleness."

"I know it's unusual, but we're making a cake," junior Julia Camp said. "It'll be like a carrot cake, but with a little bit of dill. Then the frosting will have pickle brine. Everyone says it sounds nasty, but it's actually not bad. We'll get originality points at least."

Story 6 — Write: 1-line headline counting 24-30

The student council has hired junior Caleb Hurring as the official DJ for Saturday's winter formal dance after the contracted DJ canceled at the last minute.

"We called every DJ within 100 miles to see if they could do it at the last minute," senior class president Shayla Afualo said. "We couldn't find a professional DJ that was available, but I've heard Caleb spin. He's honestly good. People are going to be surprised at how good he is at this."

Since Hurring is a current student, he is ineligible to be paid with student council funds but has agreed to work for two free prom tickets for the next two years.

"I would have done this gig for free," Hurring said. "They don't know that, but it's true. I've been DJing for about five years now. I make my own music in Logic Pro. I play at parties all the time. Still, this will probably be the largest event of my career. I'm hoping it will lead to more opportunities to do what I love."

Student council sponsor Craig Rednour said he hopes having Hurring DJ the dance leads to more students sharing their talents with the school.

"It's highly unusual that we allow a student to do something like this," he said. "We made Caleb sign a contract that everything he did with lights would be safe, and we won't hear any offensive language. Other than that, it's up to him. I'm actually pretty excited to hear this kid spin."

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Headline Writing Entry Sheet

All letters (upper and lower case), numbers, punctuation marks, symbols and spaces count as one (1). Place one letter or other unit in the appropriate spaces below. Remember to leave spaces between words. Note that the number of lines you are given on this sheet corresponds to the number of lines required for each headline. Write your number on the upper right-hand corner of this sheet.

■ Headline Number 1

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 2

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 3

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 4

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

main headline

secondary headline

■ Headline Number 5

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

main headline

secondary headline

■ Headline Number 6

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

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Headline Writing Contest Tips and Samples

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judges.

1. Headline writing is different than the other contests. It is suggested you pace yourself. You have about five minutes for each headline. Don't watch the clock, but be aware of the time you are taking to complete a headline. It is better to have four or five good headlines rather than six mediocre ones.
2. When writing the headline, first highlight or underline all the important words in the story. Then write a sentence based on those highlighted words.
3. After you have your first sentence, go back and begin editing out words. If you have a multi-line headline, separate the lines at a recommended area. This means you should not split phrases or ideas. Make sure all types of phrases — noun, verb, adverbial, adjective and prepositional phrases especially — are on the same line. Continue eliminating words until you get to a point where the headline fits. It may be necessary to re-write the headline one or more times or to take a different approach before you get the key idea. Remember to eliminate all unnecessary words such as article adjectives (a, an, the). In many cases a comma (,) can substitute for the word "and."
4. You may use a printed thesaurus or dictionary without any notes or markings inside. You may write in upstyle or downstyle.
5. Make sure you are within the prescribed count. Under no circumstances should you be under or over the maximum count. Judges are instructed not to consider any headline under or over the prescribed count.
6. Write headlines using active verbs in either present, future or present perfect tense. Follow the style of the headline. If it is a fun story, write a fun headline. If it is a serious story, write a serious headline.
7. Do not sacrifice accuracy for creativity or cuteness.
8. Normally, the main headline is used to grab the reader's attention. It is not necessary, although it is possible, to have a verb in the main headline when you have a secondary headline. The secondary headline should do one of two things: emphasize the significant aspects of the story or emphasize the unusual.
9. AP Style provides guidelines for headline writing. It is not required for contestants to follow AP Style, but a consistent style is recommended. Students may use a printed AP Stylebook (with no notes or markings inside) in the contest.

The following are additional basic headline rules for you to follow:

- avoid starting the headline with a verb
- use single quotes
- avoid using the same word twice in a headline
- avoid unfamiliar abbreviations
- do not end the headline with a period or exclamation point

★ STORY #1

Cafeteria to host tasting event	31
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★ STORY #2

Store donates 80,000 parts	26
to new auto tech class	22

★ STORY #3

Crews to apply filters	22
to main hall windows	20
to save confused birds	22

★ STORY #4

Rules of Law	12
District attorney to speak	26
to senior English classes	25

★ STORY #5

A Fair Dill	11
Students to enter pickle contest	32

★ STORY #6

DJ to put new spin on dance	27
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